

Aynura Erejepbaeva

Prof. Aldrich and Bouba

What's in Your Toolbox?

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What is the Story of Your Name?

Erejepbaeva Aynura Muratbay Kyzy. Aynura translates to 'Moonlight' in English from Karakalpak, a Turkic minor language in Central Asia. It is only a female name and cannot be used interchangeably. Aynura is common in most parts of Kazakhstan, Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan, and has various versions of spelling like 'Oynur' and 'Aynur' that exist in Turkey. Even though my community is religious and believes in Islam, I do not find my name to be religious.

When it comes to my surname 'Erejepbaeva,' it gets quite complicated because it is a Russified surname that has been in practice since the Soviet Union. Erejepbay is my grandfather's name by my dad's side and '-va' is an additional suffix added to refer to a female. It is interesting how surnames are gendered in my culture. While Muratbay is my dad's name, *Kyzy* is just a word that means 'daughter of' in Karakalpak.

Until I stepped outside of Uzbekistan, no one had ever struggled to pronounce my name correctly. I found that especially English speaking people find it difficult to emphasize the letters 'A' and 'Y' in the literal form and keep pronouncing them as 'ey' and 'why.' At first, I would get disappointed at them—it is so obvious, why don't you make some effort?, I would think critically of them. Later I got used to it—I keep repeating my name until they get it just right.

Just a bit of background on how I was named as Aynura. In Uzbekistan, it is mostly elderly people that make important decisions for family members. That includes naming grandchildren and the next generation. Since my grandfather had already passed away by the time I was born in 2006, my grandmother had a chance to name me. I was born past midnight on one of the scorchy summer days and ‘the moon was almost full and light at that time’, she says. My mother tells me she really struggled with delivering me, because of how her health disproportionately worsened due to getting pregnant just one year after my elder sister was born. Just how the moonlight really lights up the dark night and brings hope to people, I was quite literally named ‘Moonlight’ that my grandmother hoped I could illuminate paths. It also symbolizes beauty, femininity, and protection.

My name carries subidentities of me. If you ask my friend Tina about who Aynura is, she can list things like my facial features, where I am from, what I like to do, and everything that she has gotten to know about me since a year at Dartmouth. My name, then, metaphorically carries a dictionary that gives a definition of being me and being Aynura. Then, that is the reason I get disappointed sometimes if people do not pronounce it correctly. Because with an attempt to pronounce someone’s name correctly, we are shaping that character, instead of erasing it. If we dig deep enough, it is obvious that the way we name objects and humans come through how language evolved. We don’t take it personally if our pet can never pronounce our names. Perhaps, we put an expectation on human species to pronounce our names correctly because they have reached the capacity to do so. Indeed, as simple as a name—an abstract thought—can mean a lot to us.